



HINDU AUM SYMBOL



BUDDHIST WHEEL OF THE LAW



JEWISH STAR OF DAVID



CHRISTIAN CROSS

### Religious symbols

The Aum symbol represents the sacred Hindu syllable for God. The wheel of the law represents both the teachings of the Buddha and the cycle of death and rebirth. The six-pointed hexagram or Star of David is widely accepted as the symbol of Judaism, although it has only been adopted as such over the last 200 years. The cross in Christianity is symbolic of the death, and resurrection, of Jesus Christ.

## The emergence of Islam

Islam emerged in the 7th century CE. It recognizes the transcendental god of Judaism and Christianity, but by the name of Allah. The Prophet Muhammad promoted a doctrine based on personal divine revelation, which was incorporated into the holy book of Islam, the Qur'an.

### Traveling faiths

From their Asian beginnings, Hinduism, Buddhism, Judaism, Christianity, and Islam all spread out across the globe, carried in some cases by conquering armies, in others by migrants, traders, and missionaries.

### Spread of Hinduism

Hinduism was firmly established on the Indian subcontinent by 700 BCE. From around 600 BCE, belief in reincarnation was established and Hinduism spread on a wave of popular fervor from India into Sri Lanka, Cambodia, and Malaysia. It reached Indonesia and the Philippines in about the 1st century CE. Hinduism also evolved into a wide range of branches and sects, each

devoting itself to a particular deity or aspects of a deity. The largest and most universal of these were the *Vaishnava* and *Shaivite* movements, worshipping the two main creator deities, Vishnu and Shiva. Much of the burgeoning popularity of Hinduism also stemmed from the set of religious texts known as the *Puranas*, committed to writing in 450–1000 CE, but known in oral tradition from much earlier. Despite a multitude of different facets, Hinduism became a powerful cohesive force among people who were disparate in language, culture, and social position.

### Paths of Buddhism

In the centuries after the death of Gautama Buddha (c. 483 BCE), members of the Indian *sanghas* (communities of monks) elaborated his teachings and paved the way for the development of a host of schools. One of the principal branches, *Hinayana* Buddhism, following the ancient “way of the elders” or *Theravada*, arose in the 4th century BCE and spread mainly south and east from India into Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Cambodia, Laos, and Thailand. The other main branch, *Mahayana* (the “Great Vehicle”) Buddhism developed later, in the 1st–3rd centuries CE, and became the dominant element in 300–500 CE, spreading mainly north and east. Among *Mahayana*’s splinter sects is the influential *Vajrayana* school, also sometimes called tantric Buddhism. Other more austere *Mahayana* schools were carried by itinerant monks through China and thence to Japan, where further adaptation resulted in Zen Buddhism. The faith has been described as the “Vagrant Lotus” because its history has been one of migration from one culture to another. As a result, the Buddhism of India stands in sharp contrast with that found in Japan and Korea.

### Jewish diaspora

The spread of faith often went hand in glove with politics, and Judaism was no exception. Dispersal began with the forcible deportation of the Jewish elite to Babylon in 587 BCE, thus triggering the *diaspora*—the scattering of Jewish communities outside the Land of Israel.

The process intensified when the Roman general Titus sacked Jerusalem in 70 CE, causing many inhabitants to flee. By the end of the 1st century the local population had largely recovered, rebuilding its faith through observance of the Torah. Although the Romans protected the right of Jews to practice their religion throughout most of the history of the empire, they targeted Judaism after several revolts in the 2nd century CE. The emperor Septimius Severus (193–235 CE) instituted a tax on self-identified Jews and forbade conversion to Judaism. From 527 CE the Byzantine emperor Justinian subordinated Jews to orthodox Christians. Jews continued to use the trade networks of the empire, however, establishing themselves wherever trade took place. By 600 CE they had founded settlements as far as Cordoba in Iberia, Cologne in Germany, Oxyrhynchus in Egypt, and Xarax at the mouth of the Persian Gulf. Jewish populations became particularly concentrated in Asia Minor and in Mesopotamia.

### Footsteps of Christianity

The Roman Empire was also largely responsible for the spread of Christianity. Although successive emperors suppressed its fledgling communities, St. Paul was able to move freely across Europe and establish Christian cells in Corinth, Ephesus, Galatia, Thessalonica, and elsewhere. When Emperor Constantine the Great converted to Christianity early in the 4th century CE (see pp.148–49), expansion truly gained pace.

Even before the reign of Constantine, Christianity had extended rapidly into Syria and northwest into Asia Minor and Greece. In the 2nd century a thriving community of Greek-speaking Christians was established in the Rhone valley in France, and by 200 CE the Church was also well established

### PROPHET (c. 570–632 CE)

#### MUHAMMAD

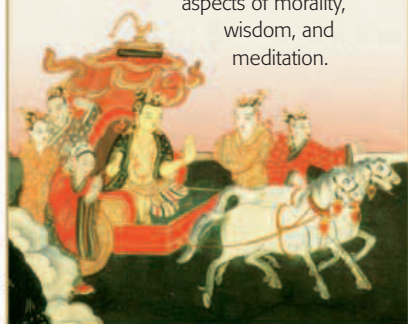
Born in Mecca, Muhammad succeeded in ridding southern Arabia of polytheism and replacing it with the worship of a single God, Allah. In Islamic doctrine he is the “end of a line” of prophets, the ultimate deliverer of divine revelation. From about 610 CE he witnessed a series of angelic visitations that became the foundation of Islamic theology. In 622 CE, in a journey known as the Hegira, he fled Mecca to escape persecution and settled in Medina with a growing band of supporters. In 631 CE he returned to Mecca on a final pilgrimage, accompanied, it is said, by 120,000 devotees. He died in Medina at age 63.

in North Africa, centered on Carthage. To the northeast, beyond the imperial frontier, a language barrier slowed progress, although by the 3rd century a church was founded at Edessa in modern Turkey. However, most missionary work was focused on Western Europe—in Italy, France, and Spain. Britain probably felt little influence until the mid-3rd century, but by 400 CE it was largely Christian.

### MONK (c. 563–c. 483 BCE)

#### GAUTAMA BUDDHA

Also known as Shakyamuni and Siddhartha, he lived in northern India during the 6th and 5th centuries BCE. One of the many ascetic philosophers of his day, he achieved enlightenment—an awakening to the ultimate truth—at Bodhgaya and subsequently wandered for the rest of his life teaching Buddhist philosophy and gathering a community of disciples or *sangha*. He taught the Eightfold Path to enlightenment, which includes disciplined guidance on all aspects of morality, wisdom, and meditation.



### Spreading the Christian faith

St. Paul (Paul of Tarsus) received a rabbinical education in Jerusalem. Originally an opponent of the early Christians, he was converted c.33 CE and became the leading Christian apostle, or missionary, especially among the non-Jewish communities. Upon arrest by the Roman authorities, he appealed to the emperor but was executed c.62 CE.